

// THE ADS YETI • FOUNDER CASE STUDY • EVERTREK

Built on belief.

How a founder-led adventure brand used Meta to grow from 14p leads to a £3m+ business whose customers stayed even when the trips stopped. What worked, what didn't, and what you can steal for your own brand.

// BEFORE WE START

This one's written with our own money.

Most case studies are an agency writing about somebody else's business. This isn't that. EverTrek is my company. Every pound in here came out of our bank account, and every lead had to turn into a real person standing at the start of a real trek before any of it counted.

When I started EverTrek in 2016 I didn't have a marketing team. I was the marketing team. I built the website, wrote the emails, made the ads, built the funnels and then sat there wondering where the bloody bookings were.

Ten years later, I think the most useful thing I can share isn't a clever targeting trick. It's how the ads and the brand ended up working together, and why that turned out to matter far more than any single campaign. So here's the story, in roughly the order we learned it, with the bits I think you can genuinely use pulled out along the way.

Andy

FOUNDER • EVERTREK & HEAD ADS YETI



// TEN YEARS, FIVE NUMBERS

The short version, if you're reading this on your phone.

YEAR ONE

14p

Cost of a Facebook lead in 2016, when it was very easy to think you were a genius.

TODAY

£3m+

The adventure travel business EverTrek grew into from a one-man startup.

THE TEST

95%+

Of customers offered a postponement during COVID stayed, through roughly 20 months of no trips.

THE SCALE-UP

£4 → £4

Cost per lead held flat while monthly Meta spend went from £4k to £14k.

THE "DEAD" LEAD

£18k

In bookings from one Facebook lead that most reports would have written off.

None of those numbers came from a single ad. They came from Meta finding the right people and the brand giving them a reason to stay. That's what the rest of this document is about.

// PART ONE

The journey.

From a kitchen-table startup to a brand people would rather stick with than shop around from. Four chapters, roughly in order.

Leads cost 14p. Lookalikes were witchcraft. And nobody was booking.

This was 2016, a wonderful time to convince yourself you were a Facebook Ads genius. Leads cost about 14p, a 1% Lookalike Audience felt like magic, and we all thought Messenger bots were going to replace email. (OK, I did a little.)

The ads worked, in the sense that Ads Manager was full of lovely numbers. CTR up. CPC down. Engagement flying. But it was my money, and I wasn't really interested in CTR. I wanted to know what came out the other side.

That question shaped everything after it. Not "what did Facebook say worked?" but "what actually made someone book a trip?" I've been trying to answer it ever since.

WHAT WE LEARNED

Cheap leads are a vanity metric with better manners.

A lead is the start of a conversation, not the end of the job. If you only measure what happens inside the ad platform, you'll optimise for whatever's cheapest to produce, which is rarely the thing that pays the wages.

The best marketing we did didn't look like marketing.

Alongside the ads, we just kept turning up. Regular Facebook Lives. A community group where people asked questions and, increasingly, answered each other's. Over time customers started calling themselves **EverTrekks**.

THE FACE

Founder on camera

Lives, Q&As, Tuesday Tune-Ins and podcasts. Plenty of rambling mixed in with the useful bits.

THE ROOM

A place to belong

A community where people who'd never met swapped training tips and calmed each other's nerves.

THE RITUALS

In-jokes that stuck

The Yeti Pose. Neck buffs. "Andy and Dave bingo" in the comments. Nobody planned these.

THE HELP

Ask a Yeti

Real answers about fitness, altitude and kit, given freely, whether or not anyone was about to book.

"Just showing up, having a chat and trying to be useful. Turns out that might have been marketing too."

The gap between booking and going isn't dead time. It's where the brand gets built.

In the early years there wasn't much between someone paying a deposit and turning up at the airport. Then, around 2018, feedback from an Everest Base Camp group told us people didn't feel prepared enough.

Rather than getting defensive, we built a personalised Trip Planner. It ended up about **80 pages long**, with the customer's name on it, fitness plans, maps and practical advice. People carried it, scribbled in it, photographed it and shared it online.

The lesson wasn't "give people more information". The planner changed the relationship. We stopped being a trip provider and became an adventure partner.

WHAT FILLED THE GAP, BIT BY BIT

Preparation emails · Personalised videos · The Trip Planner · An app with maps and countdowns · Ask a Yeti · Timed notifications · Arrival messages · A members' area · Training content · Tuesday Tune-In · Podcasts · The community

None of it came from a master plan. Together it became the glue between EverTrek and the customer, and it was still there when the trips weren't.

85 customers were due to fly to Nepal the next day. Then the world shut.

I was on a ski trip in Morzine when it became real. Within hours the team were calling customers to tell them they couldn't travel. I'll be honest, I had a proper wobble. If everyone wanted their money back, would EverTrek still exist? We couldn't promise anyone a date. We could only promise how we'd behave.

So we stripped out cancellation and deferral fees, made it simple to keep your trip, and within the first week started live Q&As on Facebook. No formal updates from a faceless company, just us, stuck at home like everyone else. For roughly 20 months we couldn't take anyone trekking. **More than 95% of the customers offered that route stayed.**

COVID didn't create the loyalty. It revealed it.

// THEN WE TURNED THE DIAL



We tripled Meta. Cost per lead didn't move.

Years of trust deposits change what scaling feels like. Between June and November we took monthly Meta spend from £4k to £14k. Normally that's where costs start running away from you. They didn't.

MONTHLY META SPEND

£4k → £14k

June to November

MONTHLY PAID SOCIAL LEADS

3,500+

Up from 800–1,000 a month

COST PER LEAD

£4 → £4

Held flat while spend tripled

WHAT HAPPENED NEXT

Organic and paid search climbed alongside it: volume, leads and conversions all up. **Meta captured the interest. Search converted the intent.**

EverTrek account data, June to November. Search and organic movements are directional, not a claim of causation.

// A JOURNEY THE REPORT COULDN'T SEE

The £18,000 lead that a 30-day report would have called a failure.

DAY 0

Facebook ad

Downloads one of our guides. Doesn't buy. Doesn't speak to sales. Carries on with their life.

MONTHS PASS

Stays in our world

Gets the emails. Sees the content. Has a look around. Nothing in any report.

THE RETURN

Downloads again

A second download triggers our sales team. Somebody actually notices.

THE CHAT

A WhatsApp

A human conversation. Questions answered. No hard sell.

A WEEK LATER

~£18,000 booked

Nearly £18k in bookings from a lead that looked dead for months.

Now, it's one customer journey, and I'm not going to build a strategy around one example. Facebook doesn't get to stick £18k in its attribution column and take the afternoon off. But it shows how messy buying really is. **There's a big difference between a bad lead and a good lead that isn't ready yet.** Most reporting can't tell them apart.

// FROM THE FOUNDER

"Someone might first discover us through a Meta ad, then Google EverTrek a few weeks later, read a blog, watch a video, come back through Search and finally book.

That's why good written and visual creative has an impact way beyond the platform it originally appeared on."

Andy

FOUNDER • EVERTREK & THE ADS YETI



// PART TWO

What you can steal.

Four things from the EverTrek story that work in any business where people think before they buy. Each one ends with something you can do on Monday morning.

Make your customer the hero. You're Obi-Wan, not Luke.

Most ads are full of "we offer", "we can", "we're the best". The customer is Luke Skywalker. Your job is to be the experienced guide who helps them get where they're trying to go. On Meta, that means your creative has four jobs, and most brands only ever do the first one.

Inspiration

Make the outcome, and the person they'll become, feel real. "I'd bloody love to do that."

Reassurance

Answer the scary questions early: fitness, safety, cost, "is this for someone like me?"

Proof

Let real customers and the community make the risk feel survivable.

Continuity

Carry the same hooks into search ads, landing pages and sales calls so the story joins up.

MONDAY MORNING Line up your live Meta ads and label each one with its job. Whichever of the four has nobody doing it is your next creative brief.

Keep showing up, especially when there's nothing to sell.

Founder-led brands have one unfair advantage that big companies can't buy: a real person. The Lives, the rambling Q&As, the in-jokes, the personalised video that set us apart from the four or five other companies someone was considering. None of it showed up as a conversion. All of it showed up when we needed it.

Here's the uncomfortable bit. **You can't manufacture loyalty during a crisis. You can only make withdrawals from trust you've already deposited.** Every useful post, every honest answer, every "not yet, train a bit longer first" is a deposit. And on Meta, that same content warms the audiences your prospecting reaches.

THE TOM CRUISE TEST

If Tom Cruise emailed your business, you'd use his name, make time, ask questions and make him feel important. What would it cost to give your ordinary customers a slice of that? Personal doesn't have to mean expensive.

MONDAY MORNING Book one recurring slot where the founder shows up on camera, answering real customer questions. Run the best clips as Meta ads to warm audiences.

Follow the lead home. Don't judge it at the form.

The £18k lead taught us this the expensive way. If your sale happens beyond the click, the ad account only sees the first step. You need to watch the whole route, and give it long enough to play out.



7-DAY VIEW · LOOKS LIKE FAILURE

New audiences arrive who've never heard of you. Efficiency dips. The report looks worse, and someone suggests turning it off.

REALISTIC WINDOW · LOOKS LIKE GROWTH

They research, compare, come back and buy. In our wider research, around a quarter of accounts saw exactly this three to four weeks later.

MONDAY MORNING Pull your last 20 customers and work out how long it took each one to go from first touch to purchase. That number, not Meta's default, is your judging window.

Don't let one dashboard decide who won.

Meta says it did it. Google says it did it. GA4 has another idea entirely. As the business owner, I don't really care who gets the trophy. I just want to know what helped us sell the trip. So we stopped asking one metric to answer three different questions.

Layer	The question it answers	What you actually look at
01 Channel health	Did Meta do what we asked?	Spend, reach, frequency, creative signal, audience quality, cost per lead.
02 Demand response	Did the market react?	Branded search trend, direct visits, qualified traffic, search conversion rate.
03 Commercial outcome	Did the business get better?	New customers, bookings, sales velocity, revenue, blended cost of acquisition.

MONDAY MORNING Put weekly Meta spend and branded search volume on the same chart for the last six months. If they move together, you've got a conversation worth having before anyone cuts prospecting.

// THE MOST EXPENSIVE SENSIBLE DECISION IN MARKETING

How founder-led brands optimise away next year's customers.

01

Meta ROAS dips

A soft month.
Prospecting looks like the weakest line on the sheet.

02

Budget moves to Search

Sensible on paper.
Search is efficient and closest to revenue.

03

Branded search softens

Four to eight weeks later. Nobody connects it to step two.

04

Costs creep up

Fewer new people entering the journey.
Same spend, smaller pool.

05

"Search has broken"

It hasn't. Fewer people were being given a reason to search.

Every step makes sense on its own. The damage only shows up in the gap between them, and channel-by-channel reporting is built to hide exactly that gap. If EverTrek had made this call in a soft month, I think we'd have quietly starved the very thing that made scaling work.

// FIVE-MINUTE SELF-CHECK

Is your Meta building a brand, or just buying clicks?

Tick the ones that are true today. Be honest, nobody's watching.

If you ticked fewer than five, you're probably leaving demand on the table, and you're in very good company. It's exactly where most of the businesses we speak to start.

- ☐ A real person from the business appears regularly in our ads or content.
- ☐ Our creative answers the scary questions, not just the exciting ones.
- ☐ We follow Meta leads all the way to a sale, not just to the form.
- ☐ We know our real average time from first touch to purchase.
- ☐ We agree how long to judge a campaign before it launches.
- ☐ We can see branded search next to Meta spend, week by week.
- ☐ Our winning Meta hooks show up in our search ads and landing pages.
- ☐ We stay in touch with customers between buying and receiving.

// WHERE THE ADS YETI CAME FROM

I never meant to start an agency. Which is probably why I ended up starting one.

After ten years of tinkering with all of this inside EverTrek, other founders started asking us to look at theirs. That became The Ads Yeti. We work with businesses where the sale happens beyond the click, and we judge ourselves the same way I judge EverTrek: did it help you sell more, profitably?

01

Business goals first

We start from the commercial target, then build the channel plan towards it.

02

Past the platform

Channel, demand and commercial signals, read together.

03

Creative as a brand asset

What people see early shapes what they search for later.

04

Honest windows

Tests judged on your real purchase lag, not a platform default.

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TAILOR-MADE TRAVEL ★ FAR & WIDE

Absolute Escapes



// WANT A SECOND PAIR OF EYES?

Let Andy take a look.

If you're already spending on Meta and can't quite explain what it's doing for the business, I'll look at your account the way I look at EverTrek's: from the ad, through the lead, all the way to revenue.

Your route

Where people come in, where they stall, and where you're losing them.

Your pattern

Whether Meta looks like it's creating demand that gets captured elsewhere.

Fix this first

The one change I'd make first, with a sensible window to judge it.

adsyeti.com

[add booking link here]



Where these numbers come from.

EverTrek account data

Meta spend, leads and cost per lead, June to November. Search and organic movements are directional.

2016 lead costs

Andy's recollection of early EverTrek Facebook campaigns. Approximate, and a very different market to today.

EverTrek customer records

COVID postponement retention (95%+ of customers offered the option) and the £18k customer journey. One journey is an example, not a trend.

55-account analysis

Weekly Meta and Google Ads data from UK brands, anonymised. Full detail in our Connected Demand briefing.

Correlation shows that two measures moved together over a period. It doesn't isolate creative, offer, seasonality, pricing or competitor effects, and isn't a claim of causation. Use it to ask sharper questions, not to hand out trophies.